

## **Upgrading the ARVN**

From 1964 to 1967, Abrams and Johnson worked as a team to create an army that was fit for Vietnam, even though it contained a large number of draftees and inexperienced officers. Johnson and Abrams commissioned a report called “A Program for Pacification and Long-Term Development of Vietnam,” or PROVN. From it, Abrams took the idea of “one war”—the integration of military operations and pacification.

In May 1967, Abrams reported to Vietnam as Westmoreland’s deputy commander with the responsibility of upgrading the performance of the ARVN. Over the next six months he traveled to every ARVN command in the country. When the Tet Offensive erupted in January 1968, the ARVN’s improved response was credited to him. Abrams himself directed the US–ARVN counterattack that retook Hue during the Tet Offensive.

## **Abrams’s war**

Upon replacing Westmoreland in July 1968, Abrams began implementing his “one war” concept. He cut back on the heavy use of artillery against villages and on the large-unit rural sweeps that often hurt civilians. Instead, he employed small-unit patrols to interrupt enemy supplies and provide more local security. While the shorthand for Westmoreland’s method had been search-and-destroy, for Abrams it was reconnaissance in force—now referred to as clear-and-hold. Success was measured by the number of towns and villages under the control of Saigon. For Abrams, it was a complex effort that required more time to implement than he had at his disposal. The political will to continue US intervention was already gone by then.

Abrams commanded an American force that numbered only 47,000 when he turned MACV over to General Frederick Weyand in June 1972. In his new appointment as US Army chief of staff, Abrams worked to restore morale and purpose to the institution that had been his life, and whose pride and reputation had been battered by an unpopular war. He was still serving in this position when he died of cancer on September 4, 1974.

It is unknowable whether Abrams’s “one war” approach, if started earlier, would have produced a better outcome for Washington and Saigon than what occurred, but within the US Army Abrams holds an honored place.